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BRIEFS

MUTUAL FUNDS

Mutual-fund guide lists low-cost funds

The Mutual Fund Education Alliance has just published the 1997 edition of its "Investor's Guide to Low-Cost Mutual Funds."

The 236-page guide includes details on more than 1,000 mutual funds from 41 groups of no-load funds. It also offers a section on the basics of mutual-fund investing, and a glossary of key terms.

For a copy, mail a check or money order for $15 to: MFEA, Dept. 0146, P.O. Box 410503, Kansas City, MO 64141-0146.

The alliance is a nonprofit trade group for direct-marketed mutual funds. If you order the guide, your name will be included on an industry mailing list unless you request otherwise.

Contact the group's World Wide Web site for more information: **http://www.mfea.com**

FINANCIAL PLANNING

How to find a fee-only planner

Looking for a fee-only certified financial planner? One option is to contact the National Association of Personal Financial Advisors.

This non-profit group, in Buffalo Grove, Ill., has members throughout the country who adhere to a strict code that governs how they're paid.

According to the group, a fee-only financial adviser is "compensated solely by the client, with neither the adviser (nor) any related party receiving compensation that is contingent on the purchase or sale of a financial product."

For information call 1 (800) 366-2732.

The group's World Wide Web site is **http://www.napfa.org**.

STOCKS

Value Line on target with its 1996 picks

Once again, the Value Line Investment Survey (1-800-833-0046) has proven the primacy of its stock-picking system. Value Line, available at many libraries, ranks about 1,300 companies for "timeliness" — likelihood of strong gains in the next year.

The top stocks are ranked in Group 1 and the worst in Group 3. The 100 stocks in Group 1 at the start of 1996 returned 27.0 percent; Group 2 stocks returned 21.4 percent; and on down to Group 3, at 15.8 percent. Since 1965, Group 1 stocks (changed at the start of each year) are up 10,563 percent!

Latest Group 1 additions are Ascend Communications, Biogen Inc. and C-Cube Microsystems. Others on the list (with high "safety" ranks, to boot): Star Banc, Microsoft, Diebold and Hellmerich & Payne.

TAXES

No one is immune to an IRS audit

Q. *I'm using a computer package to prepare my tax return. One clever feature is an IRS "audit check" option. For any given line, you can press a button and see how that number falls in line with national averages. Can I avoid an audit so simply?*

A. Don't count on being immune. Common sense says the risk will be reduced if your deductions fall within these guidelines. But if one or more deduction exceeds the norm, your tax return will have a significantly greater probability of audit. Don't be overly conservative, though. If you have a legitimate deduction, claim it — but make sure you have proper documentation.

— *Democrat news services*

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SCHOOL OF BUSINESS AND ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Slow-loading nature site worth the wait

Fred A. Schneyer
CYBER BYTES

I've never been much of a birdwatcher. But, after seeing the Peterson Online site, **http://www.petersononline.com/**, I'm ready to pick up the binoculars and look skyward.

Although it's a slow loader, Peterson Online is one of the few Web sites actually worth the wait. Not only is it graphically attractive, it's packed with an enormous amount of information about birds and nature. The interactive division of publisher Houghton Mifflin put it up just after the July 1996 death of famed naturalist Roger Tory Peterson.

Check out the index and you'll see what I mean. Not only is there an extensive collection of links to Internet birding resources, there's a birding calendar, a coloring book and a listing of bird clubs. You'll also find information about bird migration, feeding, breeding, nesting and more.

It's worth noting that this is also a good example of how to sell on the Internet. There's so much good stuff here that you don't mind Houghton Mifflin hawking its wares — Peterson books and CDs in this case.

The only thing I don't like is the use of dropdown boxes to navigate around the site instead of easier-to-use navigation bars. But overall it's a high-flying effort.

Sites and Sounds of the World Wide Web

■ A new site from the Federal Aviation Administration is another good example of the highest and best use of the Internet.

Given all the focus on air safety lately with the ValuJet and TWA crashes, the FAA's Aviation Safety Data site, **http://nasdac.faa.gov/internet/** couldn't be more timely.

You can search three government air-safety databases. Those include National Transportation Safety Board accident reports and FAA reports of "potentially hazardous events" not causing great aircraft damage or hurting passengers. You can also search NTSB recommendations on air-safety improvements.

■ Speaking of Internet search engines, get a look at a new one at the Library of Congress site, **http://lcweb2.loc.gov/ammem/booksquery.html**.

The site allows you to search for words in all languages as well as for book titles, subjects and authors. You can also search by publisher, category and Library of Congress collection.

■ For significant events in black history, search Black Facts Online, **http://www.blackfacts.com/**. Also don't miss the site's vision statement by a Massachusetts software developer calling for more black Americans to use the Internet and technology in general.

■ The Samuel Adams beer company has a neat site, **http://www.samadams.com/**, with full facts, a beer history and a beer glossary.

■ The CMP computer publishing company has come up with another worthy site, Tech Helper, **http://www.techweb.com/helper/**. If you're having a computer problem, head for this site's database of more than 500 frequently asked questions and tips from Internet discussion groups. The FAQs and tips are in 18 categories including monitors, printers and scanners.

■ If you like being in the dark, you should go by the National Caves Association's home page, **http://www.cavern.com/**. There are links to Internet cave sites and a list of frequently asked questions on caves.

■ Good night, John Boy. Good night, Mary Ellen. You can almost hear the closing line of "The Waltons" TV show at its Web site, **http://www.the-waltons.com/**. There's an episode list for the show's nine seasons and you can find out more about the cast and theme song.

There's so much good stuff here that you don't mind Houghton Mifflin hawking its wares — Peterson books and CDs in this case.

Reach Cyber Bytes via the Internet at **fschneye-tdo.infi.net**. *Please put the words "Cyber Bytes" in your e-mail subject line.*

■ *This and other features can be found on the Internet at http://www.tdo.com*

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